Khan's coming to power. She has also vowed that "there can be no elections until the scales of justice are balanced". Whether this means a reversal of the legally controversial judgments against Sharif or Khan's own disqualification remains to be seen. Many in the PDM also feel that a few of the current judges still hold a soft corner for Khan and go out of their way to forgive his trespasses, unlike their far more strict interpretations of the law against his political rivals.

THE NAWAZ FACTOR

Former three-time PM Nawaz Sharif continues to remain abroad in the UK, where he had gone in 2019, ostensibly for a few months of medical treatment. Khan continues to claim that he was duped into allowing Sharif to travel abroad from jail while PTI followers use it as a rhetorical stick to beat its main rival in Punjab with. While the PML-N is feeling the absence of its most charismatic leader on the ground and its top leadership realises Sharif will be crucial in boosting its recently dwindling political fortunes, most observers feel the party will only give the go-ahead on his return once it's clear that he will not be arrested and sent to jail on arrival; he is still to serve out the remainder of a seven-year jail term. That can happen only if some sort of understanding is reached with the judiciary or conditions are in place where the PML-N feels that those judges allegedly partial to Khan are not dictating events. Also, if Khan is disqualified from becoming prime minister again should he be convicted for the crimes he is being accused of, there could be a mutual deal to allow Sharif and Khan to contest the elections.

The sense of political panic suits Khan's politics, since he positions himself as the only person who can get Pakistan out the many crises it seems mired in, even though he may well be the reason behind them. Many of his critics liken him to America's Donald Trump and Brazil's Jair Bolsonaro. A political crisis is the last thing Pakistan needs as it grapples with an existential economic crisis, but that is how things stand.

Meanwhile, cracks are also starting to appear in the ruling coalition as the crisis gathers steam. The economic events are fully consuming the Shehbaz Sharif government at the moment but, in the background, allies like the PPP, the Muttahida Qaumi Movement-Pakistan (MQM-P) and others are voicing some dissent, and keeping a close watch on how they can battle anti-incumbency when the elections do roll around.

In this regard, the PPP may have lucked out by virtue of being the junior partner in the coalition. It has used this time to strengthen its hold on Sindh and, by staying away from the federal economic ministries, managed to avoid the direct brickbats from the electorate about the state of the economy. Its chairperson Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari has also been able to use his position as foreign minister to build international contacts for the future. But the threat from Khan's resurgent PTI might still force the PML-N, the PPP and others to confront it as allies in the future, despite their differences.

There is one thing, however, that most observers are clear about: elections might offer a diversion and new faces at the helm of the government but are unlikely to change the basic dynamics of the political and economic crisis Pakistan is in. ■



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